



race and eventually the race went well. With God's support, we won." Before rowing, Diljot was a hockey player in Chandigarh. Her first exposure to the sport came at Sukhna Lake during the final year of her BA degree. She represented Sri Guru Gobind Singh College in inter-college competitions before eventually joining IIS.

Rowing came late, but it stayed.

Now training at IIS alongside Haryana's Suman Devi in the women's coxless pair, Diljot won bronze at the Asian Rowing Cup in Chungju, South Korea, earlier this year. The duo clocked 8:02.384 to qualify for the Asian Games. For Diljot and Suman, that bronze was proof that India had a crew capable of competing at the continental level if the months before Aichi-Nagoya are used well.

Negotiating choppy waters

The other qualified women's boat from IIS carries a different story.

Thangjam Priya Devi has been around rowing long enough to know that a boat does not move on strength alone. It moves when two athletes learn to feel the same rhythm.

In Chungju, Priya and Poonam found enough of that rhythm to win bronze in the women's double sculls. Their time of 7:49.729 secured qualification for the 2026 Asian Games and earned Priya another chance on the continental stage after her appearance in Hangzhou.

Since those qualification races, India's rowing preparations have entered a more formal phase.

On June 1, the Mission Olympic Cell inducted 22 rowers into the TOPS Development Group following RFI trials and crew

finalisation. Among the women, Gurbani Kaur and Poonam were named in the women's coxless four group alongside Tendenthoi and

Future bright: For India's women rowers, the next few months will be about taking the promise seen in training and holding it under continental pressure. PICS: SIVASANKARA